Personal Details of 40,000 Homeland Security Workers Appear Online

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A website that publishes leaked documents said on Wednesday that it had released personal details of more than 40,000 people who work for the U.S. Department of Homeland Security, known as DHS. DHS is the government department that handles border security, **immigration enforcement**, disaster response, and protection against threats inside the country.

The released data includes names, phone numbers, email addresses, and job titles from Immigration and Customs Enforcement, Customs and Border Protection, Homeland Security Investigations, the Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency, and other DHS agencies. Some job titles showed who was assigned to special operations, **surveillance**, **computer forensics**, and **undercover** work.

Distributed Denial of Secrets, the group behind the release, said the information came from an entity calling itself the "Department of Peace," which said DHS employees "have our information, so it's only fair that we have theirs." The group said the data was harvested from the Okta sign-on service used by DHS. Okta said it is secure and has no evidence its data or systems were compromised.

DHS said it was aware of a potential **breach** and was working to address it swiftly, protect its employees, and update the public when more information is available.

Reuters said it could not immediately verify the entire **trove**, but it matched personal information about six employees in the leak to credit bureau records, and confirmed three employees' phone numbers by calling them. One said it was the first they had heard of a **breach**. Other parts of the data revealed non-public organization charts and previously undisclosed programs.

This is the third major government data leak in the past month. In September, the group ShinyHunters claimed it stole FBI data including sensitive job details and medical information. Last week, the War Department faced a lawsuit after a **breach** exposed data on millions of current and former military personnel.

Word Treasure

immigration enforcement -- Government work that makes sure immigration laws are followed.

surveillance -- Watching a person, place, or activity closely, often in secret, to gather information.

computer forensics -- Examining computers and digital records carefully to find evidence.

undercover -- Working in secret, often by pretending to be someone else, to find out information.

trove -- A large collection of valuable or interesting things, here a large set of leaked data.

breach -- A break into a secure system, or the leaking of private information that should

have stayed protected.

Background you need

A government department is a large team that carries out public work, such as guarding borders and helping after disasters.

Its workers use a sign-on service, which is a single login that lets staff reach many work systems.

If personal details from such a system are shared publicly, workers can face unwanted contact or danger, especially those in secret or sensitive roles.

That is why leaks of staff names and job details are treated seriously, even before every detail is checked.

Break it down

LEAD: A website that publishes leaked documents said it released personal details of more than 40,000 people who work for the U.S. Department of Homeland Security.

KEY EVENT: The release of DHS employees' personal details.

+- WHO: Distributed Denial of Secrets released the data; DHS, Okta, and Reuters responded.

+- WHEN: The website said this on Wednesday; it is the third major government data leak in the past month.

+- WHAT: Names, phone numbers, email addresses, and job titles, including assignments in special operations, surveillance, computer forensics, and undercover work.

EVIDENCE: Reuters could not verify the entire trove but matched details about six employees to credit bureau records and confirmed three phone numbers by calling.

CONTEXT: Earlier leaks included claimed FBI data in September and a War Department breach affecting millions of military personnel.

OPEN QUESTION: The full trove has not been independently verified, and DHS said it would update the public when more information is available.

Why it matters

Leaked names, phone numbers, and job details can put government workers, especially those in secret roles, at risk of harassment or harm. Repeated large leaks also raise questions about how well public systems protect private information.

Test what you remember

1. How many DHS workers' personal details did the website say it had released?

- (A) Three
- (B) Millions
- (C) Six
- (D) More than 40,000

2. Which group was behind the release?

- (A) Okta
- (B) Distributed Denial of Secrets
- (C) Reuters
- (D) ShinyHunters

3. What did Okta say about its service?

- (A) It said it is secure and has no evidence its data or systems were compromised
- (B) It said its data had been stolen
- (C) It said it would publish more data
- (D) It said it could not verify the leak

4. How many employees' phone numbers did Reuters confirm by calling them?

- (A) One
- (B) 40,000
- (C) Six
- (D) Three

5. According to the group behind the release, where did the information come from?

- (A) Credit bureau records
- (B) An entity calling itself the Department of Peace
- (C) The War Department
- (D) The FBI

6. In September, which group claimed it stole FBI data?

- (A) Distributed Denial of Secrets
- (B) ShinyHunters
- (C) Okta
- (D) The Department of Peace

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: B 3: A 4: D 5: B 6: B

Questions to think about

1. The entity calling itself the Department of Peace: It said DHS employees have our information, so it is only fair that we have theirs.

2. Okta: It said it is secure and has no evidence its data or systems were compromised.

3. DHS: It said it was aware of a potential breach and was working to address it swiftly, protect its employees, and update the public.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):